

Major scales

A scale is a series of notes that rise and fall over the range of an octave. Major scales are one of the most important building blocks of music.

SEE ALSO

◀ 52–53 Half steps

◀ 54–55 Whole steps

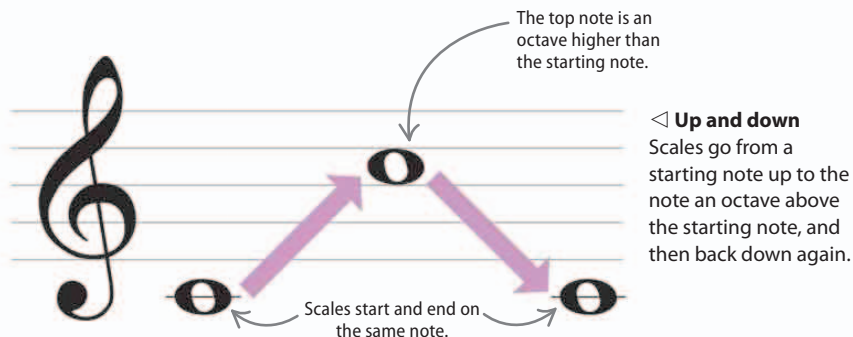
◀ 56–59 Intervals

Minor scales

62–63 ▶

What is a scale?

Scales are patterns of notes that rise up and then fall down between two notes that are an octave apart. There are two main types of scale: major and minor. Scales are played as a way of practicing a musical instrument.



The major scale

All major scales are broken down into the same pattern of whole steps and half steps. Whatever note a major scale starts on, it will always follow this pattern. The pattern of whole and half steps used on the way up is reflected on the way down—the same notes are played in both directions.

▽ Whole steps and half steps

All major scales follow the same pattern on the way up: whole step, whole step, half step, whole step, whole step, whole step, half step. On the way down the pattern is: half step, whole step, whole step, whole step, half step, whole step, whole step.

